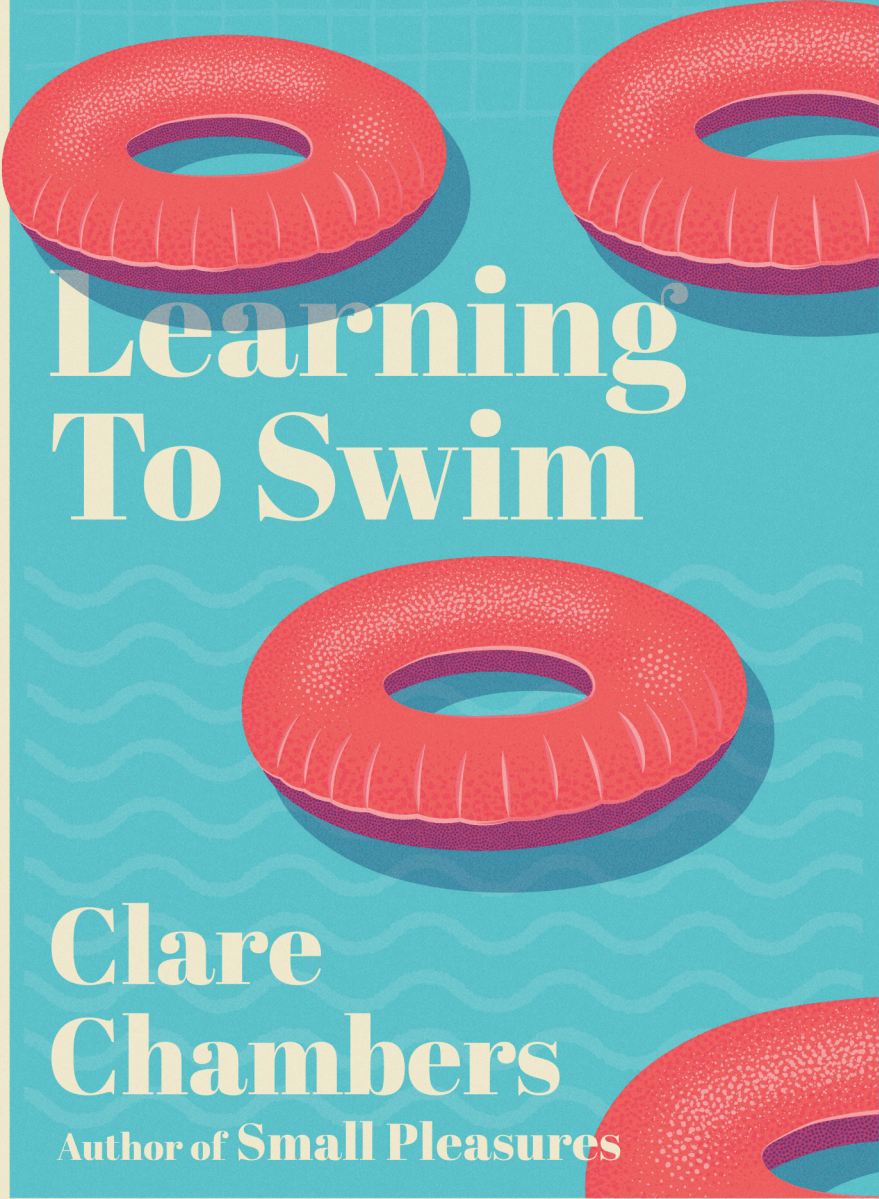


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Learning To Swim

Clare
Chambers

Author of *Small Pleasures*

Learning To Swim

Clare Chambers' first job after reading English Literature at Hertford College, Oxford, was working with Diana Athill at André Deutsch. They published Clare's first novel *Uncertain Terms* in 1992.

Clare is also the author of *Back Trouble*, *Learning to Swim*, *A Dry Spell*, *In A Good Light*, *The Editor's Wife* and *Small Pleasures*.

Since 2020 Clare has been a Royal Literary Fund Fellow at the University of Kent. She lives with her husband in south-east London.

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UNCERTAIN TERMS

BACK TROUBLE

A DRY SPELL

IN A GOOD LIGHT

THE EDITOR'S WIFE

SMALL PLEASURES

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*For
Christabel, Julian and Florence*

I

I

Loyalty never goes unpunished. My father said that once when he was passed over for promotion at work and I've never forgotten it. I went to visit my parents on the Saturday afternoon just before I was due to play in a big charity concert, having received a summons from my mother. She was having a clear-out ready for the decorators and could I come and pick up a box of my belongings or they'd end up in the church jumble sale? My mother likes to invent a practical purpose to my visits so she doesn't feel she is making frivolous, self-indulgent demands on my time.

She was in the process of sifting through a cardboard box of old, uncatalogued photographs when I arrived, and had clearly been at it for some time. All around her lay empty packets, slippery strips of negatives and neat piles of pictures sorted according to subject matter, date and quality.

'Blurred, blurred, duplicate, awful bags under my eyes, don't know who that is,' she intoned, tossing a series of rejects into the bin. I reached past her and picked up an old school photograph from the box. It was of the netball teams. There I was, standing on the end, second reserve for the B team. And there was Frances, captain of the A team, seated, holding the county trophy on her lap, that usual defiant expression on her face. I was assailed by a sudden, overwhelming sense of nostalgia – my memory has a trigger that's easily sprung – and I started leafing through the loose prints in search of other ghosts.

'Don't rummage,' mother said crossly. 'I've been at this all morning.'

'One thing I always hated,' I said, looking at my thirteen-year-old self, long hair scraped back off my face into a ponytail, my spindly legs ankle-width from plimsolls to knickers, 'was being the thinnest person in the class.'

‘You weren’t thin,’ she said defensively. ‘I would never have underfed you.’ My mother can take the oddest things personally. She twitched the photo out of my hand. ‘That’s never my Abigail,’ she said, screwing up her eyes, and then, realising that this line of argument was not going to be sustainable, said with a snort, ‘Well, I don’t call that *thin*.’



In the kitchen, my father was unpacking a new toy: a large, shiny black and chrome cappuccino machine which took up half of one work-surface. Ever since he gave up smoking his pipe – after realising that he could no longer keep up with mother’s cracking pace around museums and art galleries without wheezing – he has become increasingly addicted to modern gadgetry: anything that keeps his hands busy.

‘Hello,’ he said, blowing dust from the glass jug, before setting it on its stand. ‘Can I get you anything to drink?’

‘I’m dying for a cup of tea,’ I said, without thinking. ‘Coffee, I mean.’

‘Colombian, Brazilian, Kenyan, Costa Rican, Nicaraguan or decaffeinated,’ he asked, producing half a dozen unopened foil packets from the shopping bag in front of him.

‘Whatever,’ I said, and then thought, oh don’t be an old spoilsport. ‘Colombian.’ And I watched him meticulously measure out the beans into the grinder with a little plastic shovel, and crank away at the handle.

‘Have you got a concert tonight?’ he asked, spooning the grounds into the metal funnel and tamping them down, a rapt expression coming over his face.

‘Yes. A charity do. The Arid Lands, or something.’

‘Very poetic. Where would that be?’

‘Er . . . Senegal, I think.’

‘I meant the concert.’

‘The Barbican. Want to come? It’s only a hundred pounds a ticket.’

His eyebrows shot up. ‘A hundred pounds. That’s one whole wall plus ceiling and mouldings. Besides, there’s still all

this clearing out to do – plus the packing.’ They were off on holiday while the decorators moved in: Florence, this time. They never took me to Florence. It had been left to others to introduce me to the pleasures of the Continent.

Over the sound of hawking and spitting from the coffee machine father talked about the trip, which had been planned to the last detail. They would be staying in a cheap hotel – a former convent – some distance from the centre of the city, but it had its own restaurant, so they wouldn’t need to venture out after dark. During the day there was a punishing regime of galleries, churches and palazzos to be followed. They were going to *do* the Renaissance if it killed them. ‘Apparently all these museums and so forth are free for geriatrics,’ he said, putting a jug of milk under the jet of steam and frothing it to the consistency of uncooked meringue. ‘We’ll save a fortune. Here.’ He handed me a tall cup containing about an inch of coffee topped with a stiff peak of milk. I could see my thirst was going to remain unslaked. ‘Oh, wait. Let’s do the thing properly.’ He took it back again. ‘Cinnamon? Nutmeg? Grated chocolate?’

I glanced at my watch: I still had to pick up my sub-fusc from the dry-cleaner’s. ‘Whichever’s quickest.’

As I left, carrying my box of salvaged possessions – mostly old schoolbooks, elementary sheet music for the cello, letters, badminton and tennis racquets, and a collection of wooden, glass and pottery elephants of different sizes, amassed over many years – I noticed a pile of library books on the hall table. Background reading. Where normal people might take *Where to Eat in Florence*, my father had Machiavelli, and Giorgio Vasari’s *Lives of the Artists* as his guides.



I nearly didn’t make it to the concert because of a burst water-main at Blackfriars: on such mundane contingencies our fates hang. Part of Embankment and the underpass was closed and the traffic was gridlocked. I was forced to abandon my car on a double yellow line and take the underground – something I

would never normally do because of the rough treatment meted out to my poor cello by other tube travellers, but it was just that bit too far to carry the thing on foot.

It was crowded on the platform and I could see that no one was going to give an inch. I was already dressed in my performance gear – a precaution in case I was late – and I had to keep hoisting my long skirt up to stop it getting trodden on. When a train blew in there was a surge back and then forwards like a wave breaking and I found myself being sucked through the doors with the crowd and shoe-horned into a corner, my feet straddling the cello case.

By the time I emerged at Barbican I was convinced the poor instrument had been reduced to firewood. A few flakes of snow were starting to fall. I must be getting old because I immediately thought, Oh bloody hell. *Snow*. I've caught myself out like that once or twice lately. A few months back I had a desperately unflattering haircut but I found I was completely unperturbed. In fact I tipped the hairdresser handsomely. And at the last party I went to which was in Bristol, when the prospect of a hundred-mile drive home at 2 a.m. was beginning to look intimidating and it was suggested I might like to 'crash out' on the sofa, I suddenly realised how very far I would be prepared to drive to sleep in my own bed. Finally, the other day I used the expression 'all the rage' in all sincerity. This wasn't even acceptable currency when I was at school, but I couldn't think of any modern equivalent. The person I was talking to didn't seem nonplussed. Perhaps it's come round again. Perhaps it's all the rage.



I hardly had time to do more than check that my cello had survived the journey, and was in my seat a matter of seconds before the first violinist swept on to the stage. Grace, next to me, shot me a questioning look as we tuned up, and I raised my eyes ceilingwards. I could feel sections of my hair working loose from the clip at the back of my head. It doesn't

matter, I thought, as another hank swung down in front of my eyes. No one will be looking at you.

There was a reception afterwards. Most of the orchestra went straight home: a lot of them have young families and they tend not to linger after performances. There was no reason for me to rush off. I've always hated that moment of entering my flat alone last thing at night and will put it off if I can. Grace said she was staying: she knew one of the organisers at the charity end and felt she ought to show her face. I like her because she's a born enthusiast, but her endurance is low. She always has some new fad to promote. This season it was celibacy, which she claimed to have been 'practising successfully' for three months. I didn't like to tell her that I had been similarly disposed for the last couple of years without needing to practise. The difference was I tended to view it as a predicament rather than a hobby.

I hadn't had time to eat before the concert, having rushed home from my parents' via the dry-cleaner's, and thought I might be able to pick up a *vol au vent* or something. I'm not keen on charity galas generally. The audience aren't necessarily music lovers; they've come to gawp at the royal patron. They clap in the wrong places and seem reluctant to return from the bar at the interval. Tonight they were a well-behaved crowd, but disgruntled no doubt because the minor royal had been replaced at the last minute by a lesser breed.

I found Grace drinking champagne and reading one of the display boards illustrating the charity's work on an irrigation project. There was a sequence of photographs of some aid workers and local villagers digging a well, and some rather patronising text.

'Not exactly hard-hitting images,' I said to Grace.

'Well -' she indicated the bejewelled hordes - 'we don't want to rub their noses in it.' In our long black skirts and high-necked blouses we looked like a couple of governesses who had wandered in from the servants' quarters. One woman had already tried to give me her coat. Grace's friend, Geoff, approached us looking hassled. He was about six foot six and thin with it, and held his arms bent at elbow and wrist

as if he was being operated by strings. Grace introduced us and when he offered me the feeblest of handshakes I noticed that the cuffs of his dinner jacket were frayed and exposed a good three inches of shirt. He smelled of stale cigarette smoke. He won't remember my name, I thought.

'Lovely music,' he said, stooping to kiss Grace. 'Bloody Duchess.' He scratched his head violently, making his hair stand up in tufts. 'I suppose she can't help being ill,' he conceded.

'Do these events work?' asked Grace.

'Oh yes,' he nodded emphatically. 'I know it's easy to dismiss these people as . . .' he looked at the guests milling around in their finery, 'socialites, but they do in fact come up with the money.'

'Is this what it's all about then? Digging wells?' I asked, indicating the posters. 'Do you have full-time engineers out there?'

'If you're interested I can introduce you to the chap who's been running the project in Senegal for the last five years. Or were you just being polite?'

'No,' I said politely. 'I'm interested.'

He disappeared into the crowd and after ten minutes still hadn't returned. I picked up a glass of champagne from a patrolling waitress and thought about my car by now sitting in a pound on some bleak industrial estate off the A3 with a price on its head no doubt. I discreetly hailed another waitress who was holding a large platter of what Grace insisted were called *de luxe canapés* in catering circles. Certainly there wasn't a sausage roll or a Ritz cracker in sight. Someone – man or machine – had taken the trouble to remove the yolks from hard-boiled quails' eggs, mix them up with something creamy and pipe them back in place in little rosettes. Everything was so tiny, so beautiful, so delicately done, you could eat all night and never be satisfied.

'Oh, there you are,' said Geoff. 'Abigail Jex. Marcus Radley.'



Marcus Radley. I had rehearsed this meeting, or variations of it, a thousand times in my mind, but in spite of all this preparation failed to deliver any of the brilliant and devastating lines I'd practised over the years. Instead I said 'Hello "Marcus",' putting the faintest emphasis on his name and savouring its strangeness. His appearance was just as I had planned it: my imagination had aged him automatically so that in my mind's eye he was always two years older than me. His hair was the same – dark and curly and badly cut – as was his frown, which the uninitiated took to indicate disapproval but which occasionally signified concentration, and his eyes, which registered the shock of recognition before reverting to neutral.

'Hello Abigail,' he said, quite composed now. 'Jex.' He considered this for a second. 'Good name for Scrabble.'

Geoff, whose mind was on other things and who evidently hadn't absorbed from this exchange that we weren't strangers, said, 'Abigail was playing the cello here this evening. She's interested in hearing about the project.'

'Marcus' looked at me sceptically.

'Excuse me,' said Geoff and hurried away again, unaware of the minefield he had left us to negotiate. Grace wasn't nearly so obtuse and said, her eyes narrowing, 'Do you two already know each other or something?'

Flippancy was what was needed here, I decided. 'I'm afraid so. Marcus once branded me on the forehead with a red-hot poker. Although he wasn't called Marcus then.'

'Abigail sent me her hair in an envelope,' he said, almost smiling. 'She wasn't called Jex then.'

Grace looked at us in turn with raised eyebrows. No casual acquaintanceship this, clearly. 'So how long is it since you last saw each other?'

'Thirteen years,' we replied simultaneously, without needing any time for totting up. The ghost of a smile was gone. We were both remembering the occasion of our last meeting: the heat in the chapel; the schoolgirl soprano breaking the last of us down; the windy graveside. There was a moment's awkward silence, then in a determined effort to

get the conversation back on to safer ground, he said, 'You're a professional cellist now, then?' I nodded. 'That's good – good that you kept it up.'

'There are worse ways of being poor,' I said.

'You'll have seen most of them,' said Grace to Marcus.

'What about you?' I said. 'I gather you're not a professional . . . er. . . philosopher.'

'No,' he laughed. 'Not even an amateur. I never finished my degree.'

'Ah.'

'I've been out in Senegal for the last five years. I've only been home a month; I'm still adjusting.'

'Why did you come back?' asked Grace.

'I'd been there too long. They need someone young and enthusiastic.'

'You look young enough to me,' she said, emitting signals like a Geiger counter.

'Also the longer you're away the harder it is to settle in back home. No doubt after a couple of weeks in the office drafting public awareness surveys and arguing whether we need a new soap dish in the staff bog I'll be wishing I was back there.'

In the background I could see Geoff weaving through the crowd towards us, stopping to acknowledge people left and right. 'Marcus, can I borrow you?' he called when he was within earshot, beckoning with a skinny finger.

'Excuse me,' said Marcus. 'Someone else must want to hear about my drains. It was nice to meet you again.'

'You haven't changed a bit,' I said, then cringed at the cliché.

'Oh I have though,' he said with a half smile, before following Geoff into the heart of the party.

A hovering waiter offered us more champagne. 'Well,' said Grace, tilting her glass towards mine and winking. 'Here's to the Arid Lands.'

I examined my fingernails, waiting for the inevitable interrogation.

'Okay, in your own time.'

‘I don’t know what you mean,’ I said, innocently.

‘Oh, come off it. I’ve never seen such a shifty reunion. Talk about painful. What’s the story?’

I just laughed, enjoying her curiosity.

‘He’s not one of your old boyfriends, is he?’ she asked, too casually.

‘Why? Are you interested?’

‘I might be. He’s good-looking enough. Nice body too. I bet he works out.’

I gave her a pitying look. The Marcus Radley I’d known would readily walk ten miles to get somewhere, but he would never, ever *work out*. ‘I thought you were supposed to be celibate.’

‘I am. But I don’t want to get fanatical about it.’



What’s the story? Every time I thought I’d found a starting point I’d remember some earlier incident on which the later one depended. However far back I took it I couldn’t seem to reach the source. If only I hadn’t gone back to the house on the day Lexi left; if only Anne Trevillion had been better at tennis; if only they hadn’t taken on a new German teacher at my father’s school thirty years ago. Finally I had said, ‘I used to know the whole family. I practically lived with them when I was at school. But we lost contact.’

This is what I didn’t tell her.

II

I was christened Abigail Onions. I was meant to be Annabel but my father, in a state of heightened emotion when he went to register the birth, misremembered the very name he and my mother had spent a full nine months debating. He blamed this lapse on the fact that he had been listening to *Nabucco* the night my mother went into hospital, and the name Annabel and that of the wicked sister had become transposed in his mind. It was a long and difficult labour and an element of confusion is understandable. I suppose I should be grateful he wasn't playing *Götterdämmerung*.

After a few tears my mother resigned herself to the new name and as I grew into it she began to prefer it to the original, which she mysteriously came to decide was 'cheap', in her book the very worst thing a name – or anything else for that matter – could be.

All of this meant little to me of course. Beside the horror of my surname – ammunition for a thousand puns and paralysing introductions – the slight variation between my intended and given names was immaterial. 'Abigail' was unembarrassing – a quality I admired above all others.

We lived in a large, inter-war semi in suburban Kent. The garden, which was divided from its neighbours by knee-high fences, backed on to a railway cutting. The line was an underused commuter line operating four trains a day, and mornings and evenings would see me hopping up and down at the end of the garden waving at the dozen or so passengers as they clanked past on their way to and from work. When I was four this childhood ritual was rudely curtailed: a man in a carriage on his own exposed himself at one of the windows and when I told my mother she burst into tears and forbade me to wave at any more trains. 'Robbed of an innocent pleasure by some filthy *perv*er,' I heard her rage to father. I

didn't tell her that for some weeks I had been showing the commuters *my* knickers.

My mother was the gardener of the family. She used to talk of landscaping, as though she had mountains and rivers to tame instead of a tablecloth-sized lawn and some flowerbeds. Father was assigned various menial duties – trudging up and down with a rotary mower sending up a glittering rainbow of grassdust; digging over the vegetable patch; fetching and carrying bags of compost, and pruning anything large and spiky and liable to snag.

Roses were mother's department. All winter the stunted skeletons squatted in their beds like a reproach and a reminder of the battle that was annually waged over their tender blooms between mother's arsenal of powders, pellets and sprays on the one hand and greenfly, mildew and black-spot on the other. Her efforts were not unrewarded though, as each summer the bushes would sprout and thicken and finally erupt in a velvety mass of colour and scent. Picking the flowers was strictly forbidden. I received my first dose of corporal punishment for pulling all the heads off Baroness Rothschild as part of an experiment in perfume-making. The hand that was too gentle to crush a petal left a four-fingered bruise on my bottom through two layers of clothing. I had hoped to be vindicated by the success of my project, but the jam jar of water and rose petals turned overnight into a foul-smelling brown mush and had to be thrown on to the compost.

Our road was a tree-lined cul-de-sac, lollipop shaped, with a round green at the top from which dogs, children – indeed any creature whom it might have afforded some pleasure – were debarred, and it was used as a turning area by drivers who had overshot and missed the Bromley road – a fact which caused my mother considerable dismay. I would sometimes find her standing at the window, arms folded, staring through the net curtains, following the progress of some offending vehicle. 'Turners,' she would explain, tutting. Apart from incursions by the Turners it was a quiet road: front gardening tended to be done in silence, and

neighbours communicated across adjoining hedges and walls with nods and inflexions of the eyebrow rather than words. It was quiet inside the house too. The thick, spongy carpets seemed to swallow sound the way blotting paper takes up ink, and mother's rule about the removal of outdoor shoes meant that the three of us padded around in our socks as silently as cats. Even the cuckoo clock, a souvenir from my parents' Swiss honeymoon, had gradually lost its voice, and the little bird would emerge every hour from behind its shutters with a silent grimace instead of a chirp. Mother sometimes listened to classical music on the record player, but only with the volume on its lowest setting: oboes twittered like canaries, cymbals clinked like teaspoons, and great, roaring symphonies were quelled to a whisper.

I suppose this is why the following incident stands out so clearly in my memory. It seems strange that I can remember something that happened when I was only two in such detail, but I know I can't have been any older because I was in my cot at the time and it is well-documented in family lore that the cot collapsed when I was two and a half, trapping my fingers, and was deemed dangerous and given to the Scouts' jumble sale.

What I remember is this: some time after I had been put to bed I was woken by the sound of my mother crying, sobbing in fact. Through my open door I could see light from my parents' bedroom striping the landing, and my mother emerged dragging a suitcase. A moment later there was the clump of footsteps on the stairs and my father appeared, also crying. Then there followed an exchange of angry voices and a struggle for possession of the bag, which my father naturally won, and a tremendous crash as he flung it down the stairs. It was the only act of violence I ever witnessed under that roof and my frightened wails soon brought my mother hurrying in and she cuddled me, fiercely, to sleep. To my knowledge they never raised their voices again. It was a very civilised household.

There were also medical reasons why quietness was so revered at Number Twelve, The Close. My mother suffered

from terrible migraines which would incapacitate her for days at a time and which could be triggered by bright light, heat, noise, emotion and a variety of innocent-looking foods. She would resist their onset for as long as possible, dragging herself around the house, white-faced, her eyes pinched shut and a packet of frozen peas pressed to her forehead, until she was finally driven upstairs to seek refuge in a darkened bedroom. The ice compartment of our fridge was stocked with frozen vegetables for just this eventuality. The packs had to be circulated regularly as the white-hot intensity of mother's headaches could melt one in twenty minutes. She never complained. At frequent intervals father and I would tiptoe to her bedside and change the ice-pack or apply a wet flannel to her brow, and she would smile weakly and promise to be down soon. Occasionally I would be called upon to scrape her scalp with a metal comb, according to the principle that if the pain could not be relieved it could at least be varied.

During these periods of withdrawal father and I would be left to fend for ourselves downstairs. Refusing merely to muddle along, father would rally, fetch out cookery books from the study, drive for miles in search of obscure ingredients and produce something elaborate and quite unsuitable for a child's palate – squid, perhaps, or a fiery curry – which I would force down valiantly, all the while praying for my mother's swift recovery.

Sometimes father would think it his duty to entertain me, a situation which would cause anxiety to us both. Once when I was five he took me to a *matinée* of *Love's Labour's Lost* through which I slept soundly, and on another even worse occasion to a circus where I had to endure both the spectacle of grown men in clown costumes making themselves ridiculous and that of my father beside me writhing with boredom and embarrassment. 'Did you think I'd enjoy that, Daddy?' I asked him kindly afterwards, a story which he would often tell against himself when I was older. After these disasters father refrained from suggesting excursions for a while and confined himself to more homely entertainments –

teaching me to play backgammon and rummy, or merely sitting alongside me on the couch while we read our separate books and waited for the migraine upstairs to pass. One occasion, though, stands out from all the rest.



There has been an atmosphere in the house all morning. Not an argument, but a sense of things simmering. Our regular Saturday visit to the butcher's and the greengrocer's has been conducted in silence, and by eleven o'clock mother has retired to bed with a headache. For me this is an early stage in my growing awareness that my parents are not particularly happy – at least not simultaneously. I have begun to realise that although they don't shout at each other like couples I have seen in the Post Office, for example, neither do they show any special signs of affection. They kiss, cuddle and tease me, not each other.

While mother withdraws to her bed and father to his study, I am in the back garden playing with Margot and Sheena. By this stage (I am six) I have acquired two imaginary friends, Margot, who is slightly older than me, pretty, dark-haired and very bossy, and Sheena, who is younger, fair, pretty of course and not quite so confident. I prefer Sheena, but it is Margot who gets things done. We are practising our ballet. Margot executes a series of pirouettes culminating in a leap and Sheena and I applaud enthusiastically. Margot is already using pointes, whereas we are still in soft pumps: our feet are not sufficiently developed, is Margot's reasoning, and if we attempt to move into pointes too soon we will end up deformed and very probably crippled.

'Your turn,' she commands, and I begin the routine which I have been polishing for some days now. It is, I think, superior to Margot's, because it tells a story: it concerns a young girl who befriends a nightingale which then flies away leaving her bereft, and it is performed with as much pathos as I can manage. Sheena is very moved.

'Do you like it?' I ask Margot.

‘Yes darling, very good.’

‘Was it as good as yours?’ I persist.

‘No darling,’ says Margot kindly, ‘not quite.’

I am still recovering from this when I see father at the window. He is standing between the net curtains and the glass and gazing into the middle distance. I wave at him but he doesn’t see me. He is still in the same position when I get indoors, and I creep up beside him, under the net. He absent-mindedly puts a hand on my head and ruffles up my hair, which I promptly smooth down again.

‘Daddy?’ I say. ‘Why are you and Mummy sad?’

He jerks his hand away as though he has put his finger in a live socket and says, ‘We’re not sad, sweetie. How could we be with such a beautiful daughter?’ And fighting off the net curtains, he swings me up and gives me a kiss on the nose. ‘I’ll tell you what, we’ll go out, shall we? We’ll go out for lunch.’ This idea is very exciting to me as I’ve never eaten outside the house before.

As father is reversing the car out of the gate, the bedroom window judders open and mother appears holding a plastic bag. ‘Haven’t you forgotten something?’ she says coldly, and father yanks on the handbrake and strides back down the drive. A moment later he re-emerges with the bag, which seems to contain a brown paper package, and stows it in the boot.

‘What’s that?’ I ask as we are finally on our way.

‘An errand,’ he says, in a tone that discourages further questions.

I am sitting, legs stretched out, on the back seat – it is apparently dangerous for me to be in the front, but all right for father. This makes conversation difficult, but father is not a great talker anyway and the journey continues in friendly silence through street after street until after nearly an hour we pull up outside an extraordinary house. But for this house the road is unremarkable – two rows of tall redbrick houses, no gaps between them, small front gardens, and two ribbons of parked cars. On the corner though, set back from the road at the top of a crescent-shaped drive, squats this monster with a

turret room on each side, like a pair of hunched, bony shoulders, and windows of uneven sizes, giving it an alarming squint. The garden, a forest of unmown grass and brambles and vast rubbery bushes choked with purple flowers, is surrounded by a high wall and on top of the gateposts are two terrifying carvings. One is the head of a wolf, snarling, and the other is of an eagle or vulture – a ferocious-looking bird anyway – with a hooked beak and glaring eyes which seem to be fixed on me. While I cower on the back seat, trying to avoid their gaze, father retrieves the parcel from the boot and hurries up the driveway. His business at the front door is obscured by one of the purple bushes, but a moment later he reappears and we set off once more. His errand behind him, father seems more inclined to talk, and he tells me that he is taking me to a lovely place, one of his favourite places, a holy place called Half Moon Street, and that he hopes I am wearing comfortable shoes as there will be some walking involved. I look down at my feet. Taking advantage of my mother's indisposition I have put on my white patent leather sandals which I am only allowed to wear indoors, on special occasions. Father can usually be counted on not to notice such details. I tell him that they are extremely comfortable, which is true, and pray that there will be no mud.

We have lunch at a village pub. We sit in the garden as it is a sunny day and as children are not allowed inside. Father is extremely scrupulous about observing this sort of prohibition, and won't even let me use the pub loo; instead we have to trail around the village until we find a Ladies.

We both have steak and kidney pie and chips. When I have finished father picks over my scraps and eats the tinned peas which I have steered to the side of the plate, and the chunks of meat which I have discarded as too tough or gristly. I have my first taste of clear lemonade. How, I want to know, can something that looks like water taste so lovely? Father starts to explain about flavourings and chemicals, and then seeing my face remembers himself and asks if I would like another glass. He lights his pipe, and as the first plumes of smoke drift skywards the people at the next table pick up their plates and

decamp to the furthest corner of the garden. Sighing, father taps out his pipe into the ashtray. It is warm enough for me to have tied my cardigan around my waist, but father is still wearing shirt, tie, jumper and jacket. He always wears a tie. His wardrobe is modest and although none of his clothes are casual, none are exactly smart either. He feels the cold, too, which is unfortunate as our house is virtually unheated: any trace of warmth can bring on one of mother's heads.

Half Moon Street is reached through a tunnel of sunken lanes. The trees, newly in leaf, arch above us, blotting out the sky. All around us is the sharp acid green of spring. It is like burrowing into an apple. We have to park some half a mile away in a pub car-park and approach on foot; the path becomes a dirt track, and I have to be careful to avoid puddles. Occasionally father has to carry me across great swathes of mud. We descend into a hollow, round a corner and there it is: my first sight of Half Moon Street, not a street at all but a moss-green lake surrounded by a coronet of trees, with a tiny redbrick cottage and a jetty on one side. The garden, a waterfall of bluebells and forget-me-nots, reaches to the water's edge where there is a small wooden boat tethered to a sign which reads NO BOATING NO FISHING NO SWIMMING. The cottage is evidently inhabited as the upstairs windows are open and I can see curtains fluttering. There is a tub of wilting daffodils outside the front door and a flaking green chair with a patchwork cushion on the seat and a book hanging astride the arm. 'Last time I was here the cottage was empty,' says father. 'I'm glad it's got a tenant. It seemed such a waste.' Out on the lake a duck and some ducklings are swimming. Only their hairpin trails disturb the symmetry of the trees' reflection. It's so beautiful it isn't real.

'It's a hammer pond,' says father, and starts trying to explain about water wheels and iron smelting, but my mind has soared out of reach and I soon stop listening. I'm planning how I will live here in the future, with a friend perhaps. I already know that it is going to be one of my special places. I haven't even asked father how he discovered it. It doesn't matter; it's mine now. We make a circuit of the lake; father

walks and I run, weaving in and out of the trees and down to the water. A sign nailed to a tree reads BEWARE ADDERS, and seeing it father tells me to watch where I'm treading.

When we get back to the car an hour or so later I notice that my sandals are black with mud. Wiping them with a hanky proves fruitless – dirt is ingrained into the stitching and the leather has been grazed by twigs. They are ruined. After a few deep swallows I burst into tears and blubber out a confession. Father is sympathetic. Compared to his own shoes, which are plastered with mud, mine look quite respectable, but he knows that little girls and indeed grown women set some store by smart footwear. Besides he will be held partly responsible for their deterioration by mother and therefore remedial action is called for.

'Where did you get them?' he asks. Between sobs I tell him: it's a cheap chainstore and he is confident that we will be able to find a branch on the way home and replace them. Dorking has them but only in the beige. Reigate doesn't have my size. We finally run a pair to ground perilously close to home and the relief is immense. The old pair and the packaging from the new are discarded in a litter bin and a vow of secrecy is sworn. Father tries to make light of the deception, while hinting that he would rather it was maintained. 'We both know Mummy wouldn't really mind, but there's no point in making her cross when she's got a headache,' he says, somewhat illogically. The excitement at allying myself with father against mother is diminished by a sense of unease. I am inclined by nature to be truthful.

By the time we return, mother's headache and bad temper have evaporated and she is downstairs making a chocolate sponge – a great treat and concession, since chocolate is one of her prohibited foods, and therefore her pleasure in it will have to be entirely vicarious. She and father and I greet each other cheerfully, and after stowing the treacherous sandals in my room I am hugged and petted and allowed to lick the cake-mix spoon. In the evening, after tea, instead of retiring to his study to mark schoolbooks, prepare lessons or work on his Project – some monumental and eternally incomplete

commentary on Greek drama – father joins mother and me for a game of cards. There is some piano music playing, quietly, in the background, and we have hot milk and cake with our rummy, which we are playing for matches. We are happy, all three of us, in the same place at the same time.

My father had his own equivalent of the untreatable headache: the unexplained absence. Since mother had never learned to drive, father was Lord of the Vauxhall Viva and would disappear off in it for hours on end, usually on some minor errand, like buying a washer for the tap or paying his library fines. (As Latin master at the local Grammar School, he had unlimited access to its library and was therefore used to protracted lending times.) He never gave any warning about his excursions, but would, apparently absent-mindedly, wander out of the house, and only the revving of the car engine would alert us that once again he was Off. Occasionally he would return with some purchase or other which might legitimise four hours' absence: an obscure spare part for the car, or a stack of books in a Foyle's carrier bag. But sometimes he would come back empty-handed. To my mother this behaviour was one of those endearing eccentricities grown hateful over time, but which having gone so long unchallenged could not now be remedied. (Certain rules, like father's being allowed to smoke his pipe only in his study or in the garden, and the removal of outdoor shoes on the threshold, had been established early on and could therefore be enforced with rigour, and after a dozen years of marriage almost came naturally to him.)

He used to enact a small-scale version of his truancy within the confines of the house itself, absconding to its furthest reaches just moments before dinner was served or we were due to go out.

'Don't disappear, I'm dishing up,' mother would say, inverting a pan of vegetables into a colander in a cloud of steam as father hovered in the doorway. But by the time the food was on the plates he would be gone – ferreting in his desk for some suddenly remembered document, or making a hurried amendment to his Project.

I caught him out once. It was the Saturday before Easter. Father had slipped off just after lunch; mother was weeding the front garden. I had finished my comic and tidied my room and had decided to cycle to the shops for sweets. Cycling without support was a relatively recent accomplishment of mine, and my reward for this endeavour had been a new, red bicycle with a basket on the front and a saddle-bag on the back, to replace the rusty jumble-sale model on which I had learnt the art. Riding round and round the perimeter of the untouchable green at the end of The Close had become my preferred form of entertainment, and as I flew along the bumpy pavements to the newsagent's that morning with 10p in my pocket, I felt that sense of complete, unambitious happiness that as an adult I've rarely experienced.

Inside the shop I paused by the freezer cabinet, debating whether I would be able to get an ice cream home before it melted, when I saw father at the counter. I was on the point of accosting him, for there would surely be sweets in it for me, but stopped just in time as I saw the newsagent descend from his step-ladder and hand father a huge Easter egg in purple foil. Instinctively I dropped down behind the rack of magazines, realising that the egg must be for me, and that if I intercepted the secret I would be guilty of something, though I wasn't sure what. From my squatting position I could hear the rattle of the cash register and father saying thank you, and then to my dismay I saw his shiny black slip-ons come round the corner and advance towards me. I kept my head well down, pretending to be engrossed in a copy of *Bunty*, holding my breath for the moment of recognition, but it never came.

'Excuse me,' father said, vacantly, brushing the top of my head as he squeezed past, and was out of the door before I had even looked up.

The next morning, Easter Sunday, I woke with a vague sense of dissatisfaction and couldn't remember why. Then it came back to me: no surprise to look forward to. I had quite unwittingly done myself out of that gambler's delight in confronting a wrapped present: it's bound to disappoint, but just for a second hope triumphs. When I came down to

breakfast, however, I found the parcel next to my cereal bowl was not remotely egg-shaped. I tore off the paper to reveal a chocolate bird's nest containing several brightly coloured sugar eggs and a marzipan chick. An expression of bewilderment must have clouded my face.

'Don't you like it?' mother asked, put out by this display of ingratitude.

'Oh yes, it's lovely,' I said, remembering myself, and to prove my thorough satisfaction with the gift I began to line up the sugar eggs alongside my plate and make a great fuss of the marzipan chick.

I never saw any trace of that shiny purple Easter egg and the incident puzzled me for some time. It was only when I was a little older that it occurred to me as a possibility that father might simply have bought it for himself, since he had a sweet tooth and mother couldn't eat the stuff. The idea that a grown-up – my father – might nurse the same petty desire as me to hide himself away and gorge on unshared chocolate felt like a shocking discovery.

It wasn't until I reached junior school that my status as an only child became an issue. I suppose I must have noticed that other children and characters in books had brothers and sisters, but when you are young you accept your own situation as normal, whatever it may be. It didn't strike me that I was somehow defective until Sandra Skeet, into whose gang I had failed to ingratiate myself on the first day of term, called me an Only in the playground.

'What do you mean?' I demanded, blushing under the gaze of six pairs of hostile eight-year-old eyes.

'You're an only child – you've got no brothers and sisters. It means you get spoilt,' she replied, linking arms with her courtiers to form an unbreachable barrier of blue gingham.

'Sticks and stones –' I began bravely, reciting the infamous lie that mother peddled whenever I reported some instance of playground name-calling, but Sandra had already finished with me.

'You've gone all red,' was her parting shot as the chequered wall swung round, ready to advance on some other pariah.

From this time onwards my onliness began to preoccupy me: I was reaching the age where it no longer seemed so important to have my parents all to myself. I wanted someone to play with, to talk to after lights out, to giggle at over the tea table, but most particularly to invoke as a protector and ally in the face of the school bullies.

There were several of us in the class who had been marked out for treatment by Sandra and her friends. My surname was enough to do for me, and various other children with the misfortune to be fat or feeble, or especially dim or clever, were similarly targeted. I would suddenly become aware that I was being shunned by various sections of the class; the desk

next to mine would remain empty; people who the week before had been my friends would ignore me when I spoke or discuss me with each other as if I wasn't there. When I walked into the cloakroom the conversation would die and then unnaturally begin again on a new theme. And then, just as suddenly, without any warning, it would all stop, and Sandra would be saving me a seat at lunch, sharing her crisps with me and telling me her secrets, and for a few days life would be sweet again. It's strange that we victims never thought of getting together and forming a rebellious gang of our own, but the fact was we hated one another. And Sandra's methods were too subtle to allow for insurrection: only one person at a time was bullied, and when that person wasn't me I was so grateful that nothing would have induced me to make myself conspicuous by standing up for that week's scapegoat. In fact I was so spineless, cowardly and demoralised, that on those occasions when Sandra did make overtures of friendship in my direction I would abase myself thoroughly, even to the point of colluding with the treatment being handed out to a fellow sufferer. But those times were less common than the times when I was on the receiving end, or so it seemed; walking down an infinitely long corridor past a column of smirking girls, or sitting alone at my desk day-dreaming of the imaginary sister whose loyalty would be absolute. Break times were the worst, as we would all be turfed out of the relative safety of the classroom into the cheerless wastes of the playground, where a solitary teacher with a whistle round her neck was all that stood between me and any number of unimaginable atrocities. Skulking in the loo was out of the question as the Girls' Toilets were used as a sort of headquarters by Sandra and her gang, and wandering in there would have been regarded as an act of provocation. By denying myself drink at breakfast and lunch I had managed to train myself not to need the loo all day. On occasions when that proved impossible I would ask if I could be excused during lessons – itself a humiliation – which earned me a reputation with the teacher for having an unreliable bladder.

My parents were powerless in the face of my enduring despair. Every Sunday evening would see me labouring to manifest the symptoms of a new disease which would suffice to keep me at home on Monday.

‘Can’t you find some other nice friends?’ mother asked one night as I sat in bed snivelling into my cocoa – a low point, I remember.

‘No. There’s no one left. When Sandra starts ignoring me they all do.’

‘What about the other girls she picks on? Can’t you pal up with one of those?’

‘I don’t want them as friends. I want normal friends,’ I sobbed.

‘Doesn’t the teacher put a stop to this sort of thing?’

‘She doesn’t notice.’

‘Well, why don’t you tell her? This Sandra girl shouldn’t be allowed to make your life a misery. And mine,’ she added.

But tale-telling, I knew by some instinct, without ever having been told, was the worst crime of all for which Sandra would already have devised the ultimate punishment.

There was one person however – a girl called Ruth Pike – who was even more unfortunate than I was. As well as being dim, she was also afflicted with terrible eczema, which smothered her hands, face and legs in red, flaky patches, so that there was hardly a thumbnail-sized patch of undamaged skin left. As if this wasn’t bad enough she had serious asthma, which meant she was always wheezing and puffing on a little plastic gadget. Her alarming appearance made her a natural object of ridicule, and she was often to be found hiding behind the coats in the cloakroom, sniffing and trying to make herself invisible. Needless to say, the pity I felt for her didn’t extend to friendship. Try as I might, I couldn’t like her. Because of her various ailments, and probably because of her unhappy experiences at school, she was often absent, and the sight of her navy mack with its mittens still sewn childishly on to the sleeves with tape, hanging on her peg, would fill my cowardly heart with relief at the thought that she and not me might be the day’s sacrifice.

One Monday morning in spring, after a particularly bad week in which I had cried myself to sleep every night and mother had only been dissuaded from complaining to my form teacher by desperate entreaties from me, I arrived at school to find that the weekend had wrought a miraculous transformation and the sunshine of Sandra's favour was smiling on me once again. She was sitting at the spare desk beside mine, brushing the nap of her furry pencil case and looking up at me from under her fringe. For someone with such power she was oddly harmless in appearance, being small for her age, with very pale, almost albino skin and white blonde hair which she always wore in two thin pigtails to her waist. Her pale blue eyes with their colourless lashes gave her a slightly washed out, unfinished look, like a painting that needs some outlines. Her sister, Julie, who was at the High School, was supposed to be even more dangerous. A rumour was currently running around the class that she had held some girl's head down the loo and pulled the chain because she hadn't shown the proper respect – a punishment known as *bogwashing*. My avoidance of the Girls' Toilets had never seemed so wise.

'Hello,' said Sandra. 'Nicky's off sick today so I'm going to sit next to you. I've got some new pens. Do you want one?' She shook out the pencil case on to her desk to reveal half a dozen plastic propelling pencils which smelled of fruit.

'Really?' I said, cautiously, in case it was a trick.

'Yes, go on, have this one. Pineapple's the nicest.'

We were in the process of sniffing them all and comparing flavours when Ruth Pike came in and sat down. She had one of the few single desks at the side of the class, occupied by the disruptive or the terminally friendless, and she lifted the lid hastily when she saw Sandra and pretended to be busy sorting books, a strategy familiar to me.

'My mum says if you've got what she's got you can't wash properly because you're allergic to soap,' said Sandra loudly. The shuffling behind Ruth's desk intensified. I felt myself blushing with pity and shame. Sandra blinked at me with her pale lashes. 'You can copy me in the spelling test if you want,'